

POCO Buds X1

Effective ANC on a budget

POCO, known for its value-for-money smartphones, has entered the audio accessory market with the POCO Buds X1, launched in India at a competitive price of ₹1,699. These true wireless earbuds aim to offer an exciting feature set, including Active Noise Cancellation (ANC), without breaking the bank. With highlights such as a modern design, effective noise cancellation, and impressive battery life, the POCO Buds X1 promises a lot for its price. But do they deliver on their promises? Let's delve into the details to see if these earbuds are worth the investment.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The POCO Buds X1 sports a contemporary and stylish design. The charging case features an oval shape with a matte finish, which not only feels good in hand but also resists fingerprints and scratches. The POCO branding is discreetly placed on the back, while a white LED indicator on the front provides clear charging status updates. The case is compact and easy to carry in your pocket.

Opening the case reveals the earbuds nestled securely in their slots. Removing the buds can be a bit tricky, requiring a bit of a tug-of-war, which might be inconvenient for some users. The earbuds themselves have a glossy plastic finish that can attract fingerprints but maintain a sleek appearance.

Weighing about 4.2 grams each, the earbuds are designed for a secure and comfortable fit. They stay put even during intense physical activities like running or cycling. Additionally, they have an IP54 rating for dust and water resistance, meaning they can handle splashes and light rain but are not submersible.



FEATURES

The POCO Buds X1 is packed with features that are impressive for its price. It includes Active Noise Cancellation (ANC), which is effective up to 46dB, and a Transparency mode to let ambient sound through when needed. This feature

helps users stay aware of their surroundings, which is useful for safety.

Effortless pairing is a standout feature, facilitated by Bluetooth 5.3 with SBC and AAC audio codecs. The earbuds also support Google Fast Pair for quick and easy connectivity. However, they do not support multipoint connection to multiple devices, but that's not expected at this price point. The touch controls on the earbuds can be a bit finicky, sometimes requiring precise taps to operate correctly, which can get a bit annoying.

One of the standout features is the Xiaomi Earbuds app, available on both Android and iOS. This app unlocks advanced sound customisation with a 10-band EQ and allows for customisable controls, which adds a level of personalisation to the user

experience. In the past, my gripe with Xiaomi earphones has been the lack of an accompanying app, so it's great to see POCO address that and ship with Xiaomi Earbuds app support.

PERFORMANCE

The POCO Buds X1 delivers a bass-heavy sound profile, thanks to its 12.4mm dynamic drivers with a titanium-plated polymer. This results in a bass-forward sound signature that might appeal to bass enthusiasts but can occasionally overshadow the mids and clarity of vocals and instruments. The bass response is notably bloated and heavy, sometimes making it challenging to appreciate the finer details in the audio. The mids are recessed, so they're pretty soft in the mix.

On the other hand, the ANC is impressively effective for the price, providing significant noise reduction and an immersive listening experience. The Transparency mode is well-implemented, allowing users to hear their surroundings without removing the earbuds. Although there is no dedicated low-latency gaming mode, the reported 60ms latency should be sufficient for most casual gaming needs.

Call quality is another strong point for the POCO Buds X1. With dual microphones and AI noise-reduction technology, the earbuds are decent for making calls indoors, but they do struggle a bit outdoors, especially in the presence of strong winds.

BATTERY LIFE

Battery life is a notable feature of the POCO Buds X1. The earbuds offer up to 7 hours of use on a single charge without ANC. With ANC turned on, users can expect slightly over 5 hours of usage at around 50% volume, which is pretty good. The charging case extends the total battery life to approximately 36 hours without ANC, meaning users can comfortably go several days without needing a recharge. Finally, with a combined battery life of about 20 hours from the earbuds and